

Once you have signed up and logged in, you will notice a conspicuous delay before the Inbox shows up. This is because the Gmail interface is a single, large JavaScript file that needs to be loaded first.

Once loaded, the interface, without graphical ads, is a novel experience—no banner ads, no pop-up ads, no Flash ads, no script ads!

All Google services use Google's text-based ads, and these cannot be avoided. But they are not as visually disruptive or bandwidth-hogging as graphical ads, and it is a small price to pay to use the otherwise excellent service.

The Gmail service is available in three flavours—Standard with Chat, Standard without Chat, and HTML. The Standard ones require you to enable JavaScript in your browser. The HTML interface is not as feature-rich, but is practical and even leaner than the standard interface. Since using this interface does away with the delay in loading the JavaScript file, users on a dial-up connection will prefer it.

The first time you use Gmail, it tries to load the Standard with Chat interface. There on, it tries to load the previously-used interface by default. In case you have an unsupported browser or if JavaScript is disabled or the loading is slow, you are presented with the option to choose the HTML version, or correct the browser configuration, or change the browser. If you would like to switch between interfaces, you need to be logged in, and at the bottom of the mailbox page, you can see which interface you are using and the available interface options. Clicking on any of the corresponding links switches the interface.

10.2.2 Navigating the Standard Interface

Besides the usual folder list, the interface has a Settings link on the top right, where you can configure the service. A link to other Google services is available on the top left, which allows you to subscribe to other services such as Groups, Docs and Spreadsheets,